AQFP Cryo Rack — Design Package

2026-03-10

Revision 0.6 — March 2026

Executive Summary

This document describes the design of a self-contained cryogenic rack for deploying AQFP (Adiabatic Quantum Flux Parametron) superconducting processors at 4.2 K. The system is built entirely from off-the-shelf and standard vacuum components, housed in a 19-inch equipment rack, and designed for portability between sites.

Key specifications:

Parameter	Value
Operating temperature	4.2 K (second stage), ~40 K (first stage)
Cryocooler	SHI RDK-101D + CNA-11RC (GM, air-cooled)
Cooling capacity	100 mW @ 4.2 K, ~6 W @ 45 K
Thermal margin	>90% on both stages (with MLI)
Power	120V / 15A standard wall outlet (~2 kW total)
Cooling water	Not required
Form factor	19-inch rack (compressor rack-mounted)
Vacuum	HiCube 80 Eco turbo station, $<10^{-8}$ Torr ultimate
Magnetic shielding	FINEMET (40 K), optional Pb foil (4 K)
Cooldown time	~60–90 minutes to 4 K

Estimated cost: ~$52k for the rack build.

Timeline: 4 weeks from procurement start to operational, gated by the 12-week cryocooler lead time.

Deployment plan: Vertiv (first), then CBA and AM. The system is designed to be relocated with minimal effort — standard power, air-cooled, modular construction.

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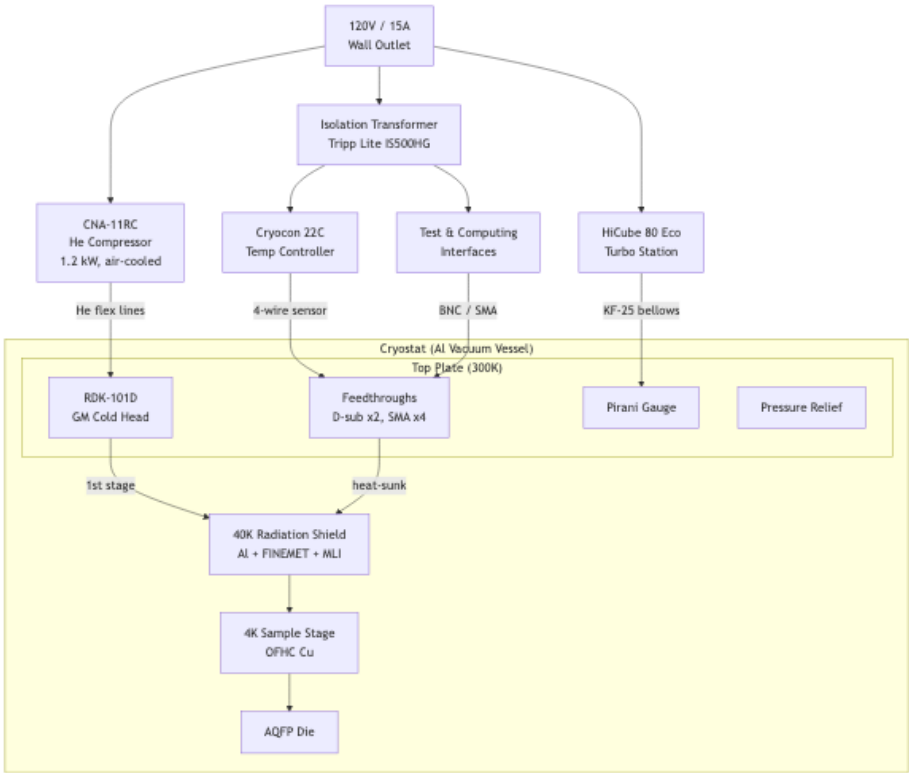
1. System Architecture

The cryo rack is a self-contained cryogenic deployment platform. A GM cryocooler, vacuum system, magnetic shielding, and instrumentation are housed in a standard 19-inch rack, with all signal and power connections accessible from the front or rear panel.



System Architecture

Thermal stages

The system has three thermal stages:

- **300 K (room temperature):** Vacuum vessel walls, feedthroughs, pump, compressor, and all room-temperature electronics.
- **~40 K (first stage):** Aluminum radiation shield with FINEMET nanocrystalline magnetic shielding and MLI blankets. Wiring is thermally intercepted here.
- **4.2 K (second stage):** OFHC copper sample stage where the AQFP die is mounted. Optional superconducting lead foil can be added for residual magnetic field attenuation if needed.

Signal path

DC bias currents are delivered via phosphor bronze twisted pairs, heat-sunk at 40 K and 4 K. AC clock signals travel on semi-rigid stainless steel coaxial cables, also thermally intercepted at both stages. All connections terminate at room-temperature feedthroughs on the cryostat top plate.

Ground isolation

The cold head body is galvanically continuous with the compressor chassis through the stainless steel flex lines. The compressor is earth-grounded through its AC power cord. The GM cycle valve motor produces periodic current transients (~1 Hz) that propagate through this ground structure.

The system uses two isolated ground domains (see ADR-004):

- **Domain 1 (earth ground):** Building mains → compressor chassis → flex lines → cold head → vacuum jacket → rack chassis. Carries compressor motor currents. No measurement signals.
- **Domain 2 (isolated measurement ground):** Isolation transformer secondary → readout electronics → feedthrough pins → copper backplane at 4 K → AQFP circuit ground. Signal and bias currents only.

Isolation is maintained by:

Location	Component	Function
4 K (cold finger)	Polycrystalline alumina disk, 25–30 mm, indium foil both faces	Breaks galvanic path between cryocooler and circuit ground
300 K (feedthroughs)	Ceramic-to-metal hermetic seals	Pins isolated from flange body by design
300 K (power entry)	Tripp Lite IS500HG isolation transformer (500 W, Faraday-shielded)	Isolates readout ground from building mains
300 K (enclosure)	Plastic isolation jacket around cryostat	Prevents accidental contact between cables and vessel

A plastic enclosure (ABS or acrylic) surrounds the cryostat body, physically preventing accidental ground contact during assembly and measurement. All cable routing passes through the enclosure via insulated grommets at the top plate interface.

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2. Cryostat Assembly

Design philosophy

All vacuum hardware is standard CF/KF catalog items sourced from multiple vendors (Kurt Lesker, MDC, Nor-Cal, Ideal Vacuum). Only the radiation shield and sample stage are custom machined — simple aluminum and copper parts any machine shop can make. No single-vendor lock-in.

The cryostat is top-loading: the cold head hangs from the top plate with the cold end pointing down. Feedthroughs are on the top plate or welded side ports. Pumping connects via KF-25 ports on the vessel body.

Vacuum vessel material

Two options for the 8” CF vacuum vessel:

Option	Material	Magnetic (μr)	Procurement	Notes
Aluminum (preferred)	6061-T6 Al tube + Atlas bimetal flanges	~1.00	Semi-COTS	Al body + SS knife edge; local weld required
Stainless (fallback)	304L SS CF nipple	~1.02–1.10	COTS (Lesker)	Works with adequate FINEMET shielding

Aluminum path: Purchase Atlas UHV 8” bimetal Al/SS CF weld-neck flanges and 8” OD 6061-T6 aluminum tube. TIG weld at local shop. Non-magnetic vessel eliminates trapped flux concerns.

Stainless path: Purchase Lesker 8” CF full nipple (304L SS). Faster procurement but slightly magnetic. The FINEMET shielding (μr ~30,000) dominates attenuation, so SS vessel permeability is a small contribution to residual field — acceptable for initial deployment.

Cross-section

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  ┌──────────────────────────────────┐
  │          COMPRESSOR              │  CNA-11RC, 120V, rack-
mounted
  │          (300 K)                 │
  └──────────────────────────────────┘
               │
               │ flex lines (He supply + return)
               │ cold head cable (motor drive)
               │
        ┌──────┴──────┐
        │ COLD HEAD   │                      Motor housing sits on
top plate
        │  (motor)    │   FT  FT  FT         FT = feedthrough ports
(D-sub, SMA)
        │   300K      │   ○   ○   ○          Pirani gauge, pressure
relief
        └──────┬──────┘
  ══════════════╪═══════════════════════════  ← TOP PLATE (300K)
  ‖           │             ○   ○   ‖     8" CF multiport cluster
flange
  ‖     ┌─────┴─────┐                 ‖     Center bore: CF seal to
cold head
  ‖     │ 1st stage │                 ‖     Viton O-ring seal to
vessel body
  ‖     │  (40 K)   │                 ‖     (reusable for sample
access cycling)
  ‖   ┌─┴───────────┴─┐               ‖
  ‖   │               │               ‖
  ‖   │  strap│  strap│               ‖  ← OFHC Cu thermal straps
(x2)
```

```
  ‖  |       |       |             ‖
  ‖  |       |       |             ‖
  ‖  |  ┌────┴────┐  |             ‖
  ‖  ├──┤ RAD     ├──┤  .....      ‖  ← RADIATION SHIELD (40K)
  ‖  |  | SHIELD  |  |  :MLI:      ‖     6061 Al cylinder + end
caps
  ‖  |  | (Al)    |  |  :   :      ‖     FINEMET ribbon wrapped on
surface
  ‖  |  |         |  |  :   :      ‖     MLI blankets on outside
of shield
  ‖  |  | FINEMET |  |  :   :      ‖     Wires heat-sunk here (GE
varnish)
  ‖  |  | wrapped |  |  :   :      ‖
  ‖  |  |         |  |  :   :      ‖
  ‖  |  |   ┌───┐ |  |  :   :      ‖
  ‖  |  |   |2nd| |  |  :   :      ‖  ← 2nd STAGE (4K) cold finger
  ‖  |  |   |stg| |  |  :   :      ‖
  ‖  |  |   ├───┤ |  |  :   :      ‖     Cu strap from 2nd stage
  ‖  |  |   |   | |  |  :   :      ‖
  ‖  |  |   | ┌─┐ |  |  :   :      ‖  ← SAMPLE STAGE (4K)
  ‖  |  |   | |P| |  |  :   :      ‖     OFHC Cu plate, gold-
plated
  ‖  |  |   || ||  |  |  :   :      ‖     Optional Pb foil around
DUT
  ‖  |  |   |├─┤|  |  |  :   :      ‖     Cernox sensor mounted
here
  ‖  |  |   |D| |  |  |  :   :      ‖  ← DUT PCB CARRIER
  ‖  |  |   |U| |  |  |  :   :      ‖     Wirebonded AQFP die
  ‖  |  |   |T| |  |  |  :   :      ‖     SMA connectors for RF
  ‖  |  |   | └─┘ |  |  :   :      ‖
  ‖  |  |   └─────┘  |  :   :      ‖
  ‖  |  └────────────┘  :...:      ‖
  ‖  └──────────────────┘           ‖
  ‖                                 ‖  ← VACUUM VESSEL BODY (300K)
  ‖  ○ KF-25 (pump)               ‖     6061-T6 Al, 6" OD tube
  ‖                                 ‖     KF ports on top plate
  ‖                                 ‖
  ═══════════════════════════════════    ← BOTTOM PLATE (300K)
                                         Blank 8" CF flange
       |             |
       |             |
  ┌────┴────┐     ┌────┴────┐
  | HiCube  |     | Pirani  |
  | 80 Eco  |     | gauge   |
  | (pump)  |     | CVM211  |
  └─────────┘     └─────────┘
```

Assembly layers

300 K — Room temperature

#	Part	Material	Interface
1	Equipment rack	Steel	Floor

#	Part	Material	Interface
2	Compressor (CNA-11RC)	—	120V wall outlet
3	Flex lines + cold head cable	SS/Cu	Compressor to cold head
4	Vacuum vessel body	6061-T6 Al (or 304L SS)	8” CF top + bottom (see §2, vessel material)
5	Top plate	6061-T6 Al (or 304L SS)	8” CF, center bore for cold head
6	Bottom plate	6061-T6 Al (or 304L SS)	8” CF blank
7	Viton O-ring (top plate seal)	Viton	Reusable sample access joint
8	CF copper gaskets	OFHC Cu	Permanent joints
9	KF side ports	SS	Welded on vessel body
10	Pressure relief valve	—	KF-25 port on vessel
11	Vacuum gauge (Pirani)	—	KF-25 port
12	HiCube turbo pump station	—	KF-25 bellows hose to vessel
13	D-sub feedthroughs (x2)	—	CF ports on top plate
14	SMA feedthroughs (x4)	—	CF ports on top plate

40 K — First stage

#	Part	Material	Interface
15	Cold head (RDK-101D)	—	CF seal through top plate
16	Thermal straps (x2)	OFHC Cu braid	1st stage flange to rad shield
17	Indium wire	In	Crushed at bolted joints
18	Radiation shield	6061-T6 Al	Cylinder + end caps
19	FINEMET ribbon	Nanocrystalline	Wrapped on rad shield surface
20	MLI blankets	Al mylar + dacron	Wrapped around shield exterior
21	Si diode sensor	—	Mounted on shield
22	Wire heat sinking	GE varnish	

#	Part	Material	Interface
			Wires anchored to rad shield

4 K — Second stage

#	Part	Material	Interface
23	Thermal straps (x2)	OFHC Cu braid	2nd stage to sample stage
23b	Alumina isolation disk	Al_2O_3 (polycrystalline)	Between cold finger and sample stage (see §1, ground isolation)
24	Sample stage	OFHC Cu	Clamped to cold finger through alumina disk
25	Lead foil shield (optional)	Pb, 0.1 mm	Wrapped around DUT area
26	Cernox sensors (x2)	—	2nd stage + DUT mount
27	DUT PCB carrier	FR4/Cu	Bolted to sample stage

Wiring path

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External instruments (GS200, 2182A)
       │ DC: BNC/banana cables
       │ RF: SMA cables
       ▼
  ┌──────────────┐
  │ Feedthroughs │  D-sub (DC), SMA (RF) — hermetic, on top plate
  └──────────────┘
         │ PhBr wire (DC), SS coax (RF) — inside vacuum
         │
     ┌───────┐
     │ 40K   │  Wires thermally anchored (GE varnish on bobbins)
     │ shield│  Intercepted heat goes to 1st stage
     └───────┘
         │
     ┌───────┐
     │ 4K DUT│  DC bias pads + SMA edge-launch on PCB
     │ carrier│  Wirebonded to AQFP die
     └───────┘
```

Vacuum path

```
  Atmosphere
       │
  ┌──────────┐
```

```
│ HiCube   │  Turbo + diaphragm backing pump
│ 80 Eco   │  KF-25 bellows hose to vessel
└──────────┘
     │
     │
┌────────────┐
│ Vessel     │  SS CF nipple body
│ interior   │  Pirani gauge on KF-25 side port
│            │  Relief valve on KF-25 side port
└────────────┘
     ↓ at 4K, cryopumping maintains <1e-6 Torr
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Modularity and cryocooler swapping

The top plate is the only cryocooler-specific part. If the cold head changes (e.g., from RDK-101D to BMC401 or a pulse tube), only the top plate needs replacement or re-machining (~$400 cost). All other cryostat components are cold-head agnostic.

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3. Thermal Budget

Cryocooler capacity

RDK-101D with CNA-11RC compressor at 60 Hz (US power):

Stage	Temperature	Capacity
1st stage	45–60 K	3–5 W
2nd stage	4.2 K	**100 mW**

4 K (second stage) heat budget

Source	Load (mW)
Radiation (40 K to 4 K)	0.3
DC wire conduction (16x PhBr 36AWG)	0.1
RF coax conduction (4x SS 0.086”)	2.0
DUT dissipation (AQFP: nW–uW)	~0
Total	**~2.4**
Available	**100**
Utilization	**2.4%**

40 K (first stage) heat budget

Source	With MLI	Without MLI
Radiation (300 K to 40 K)	120 mW	1,800 mW
DC wire conduction	3 mW	3 mW

Source	With MLI	Without MLI
RF coax conduction	35 mW	35 mW
Total	**~160 mW**	**~1,840 mW**
Available	**~3,000 mW**	**~3,000 mW**
Utilization	**5%**	**61%**

Both stages have large thermal margin. MLI is recommended but not strictly required at the baseline shield size (100 mm diameter). For larger shields (200–300 mm), MLI is mandatory — see appendix.

Shield sizing (how big can we go?)

With MLI, shield size is thermally unconstrained for any rack-mount design:

Shield (dia x H)	Area	With MLI	Without MLI
100 x 150 mm	0.063 m²	95 mW **(3%)**	1.4 W (48%)
200 x 300 mm	0.251 m²	376 mW **(13%)**	5.8 W (OVER)
300 x 400 mm	0.518 m²	777 mW **(26%)**	12 W (OVER)

A 200–300 mm diameter shield provides generous working space for multiple DUTs and complex wiring, uses only 13–26% of the first-stage budget with MLI, and fits comfortably in a 19-inch rack (450 mm between rails).

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4. Cryocooler Selection

Comparison of quoted options

Parameter	SHI RDK-101D	SHI RDC-02K	Bama BMC401	Cryomech PT205
Type	GM	GM	GM	Pulse tube
Quoted price	$27,230	$37,155	$13,000	$42,325
Lead time	12 weeks	12 weeks	4 weeks	36–40 weeks
4 K capacity	0.1 W	0.2 W	0.16 W	0.1–0.3 W
40 K capacity	~6 W @ 45 K	~6 W @ 45 K	3 W @ 45 K	TBD
Min temp	~3.5 K	< 2 K	< 2.3 K	5–6 K
120V / 15A	**Yes**	**Yes**	**No** (220V)	**Likely yes**
Cooling	Air	Air	Unconfirmed	Air
Compressor power	~1.2 kW	~1.2 kW	~1.5 kW	~1.5 kW
Maintenance	10,000 hr	10,000 hr	10,000 hr	~20,000 hr
Vibration				Low (PT)

Parameter	SHI RDK-101D	SHI RDC-02K	Bama BMC401	Cryomech PT205
	Moderate (GM)	Moderate (GM)	Moderate (GM)	

Selection rationale

Primary: SHI RDK-101D + CNA-11RC — 120V plug-and-play, air-cooled, well-established platform with extensive support. 12-week lead time.

Upgrade option: SHI RDC-02K + CNA-11RC — same compressor and rack integration as the RDK-101D, but 2x the 4 K capacity (0.2 W) and guaranteed < 2 K base temperature. $10k premium over the RDK-101D. Relevant if Phase 2 wiring loads grow or sub-4 K operation is needed.

Backup: Bama BMC401 — half the cost, 4-week delivery, but 220V/50Hz compressor is not compatible with standard 120V/15A outlets. Under evaluation for 60 Hz compatibility and potential pairing with SHI CNA-11RC compressor.

Not selected: Cryomech PT205 — 36–40 week prototype lead time and highest cost eliminate it for near-term build. Low vibration and longer maintenance interval do not materially benefit AQFP electrical testing. Reconsidering for future permanent installations.

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5. Bill of Materials

Full BOM is auto-generated from `bom/bom.yaml` (rev 0.6) by the build script. The tables below show active items only (qty > 0). Reference-only options (alternative cryocoolers, scroll pump) are excluded from cost totals.

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6. Site Requirements — Vertiv

Power

Requirement	Specification
Outlet type	NEMA 5-15 (standard US 120V / 15A)
Circuits needed	2 recommended (compressor on one, instruments on another)
Total power draw	~2–3 kW
Compressor	~1.2 kW (CNA-11RC), direct to building mains (earth-grounded)
Turbo pump	~150 W (HiCube 80 Eco)
Instruments	~200 W behind isolation transformer (Tripp Lite IS500HG, 500 W)

No special electrical work required. Standard office/lab outlets are sufficient. The readout electronics are powered through a rack-mounted isolation transformer to maintain a clean, isolated measurement ground (see §1, ground isolation).

Space

Requirement	Specification
Rack	19-inch standard, ~20U minimum
Rack footprint	~0.6 x 0.8 m
Compressor	Rack-mounted (CNA-11RC fits 19-inch rack)
Clearance	Allow ~0.5 m behind rack for cable routing and airflow
Cryostat position	Top of rack or adjacent bench

Environment

Requirement	Specification
Ambient temperature	15–30 C (standard lab/office)
Cooling water	**Not required** (air-cooled compressor)
Ventilation	Standard room HVAC sufficient; compressor rejects ~1–2 kW as heat
Floor loading	~150–200 kg total (rack with compressor + cryostat)
Vibration isolation	Not required for AQFP testing

Network (optional)

- Ethernet for Cryocon 22C remote temperature monitoring
- USB for instrument control (GS200, 2182A)

Facility preparation checklist

- [ ] Confirm availability of 2x 120V / 15A outlets near rack location
- [ ] Confirm 19-inch rack (Vertiv may supply) or designate rack location
- [ ] Confirm rack has sufficient depth for compressor (~600 mm)
- [ ] Confirm adequate room ventilation for ~2 kW heat rejection
- [ ] Assign Ethernet drop if remote monitoring desired

7. Timeline

Target: Operational cryo rack within 4 weeks of procurement start.

Week	Activities
1	Finalize cryocooler selection. Send RFQs. Order long-lead items. Complete cryostat detailed design.
2	Place all orders. Commission custom machining (radiation shield, sample stage). Begin rack layout.
3	Receive and inspect components. Assemble cryostat. Install magnetic shielding. Wire feedthroughs. Room-temperature functional tests.
4	Leak check vacuum system. Pump down and cooldown. Verify base temperature. Measure residual magnetic field. Functional test with AQFP die (if available).

Critical path

The 12-week cryocooler lead time (SHI RDK-101D) gates the overall schedule. All other components have 1–2 week lead times. During the cryocooler wait:

- Complete cryostat detailed design using outline drawing dimensions
- Procure and assemble all non-cryocooler components
- Perform room-temperature vacuum and wiring tests
- Prepare DUT carriers and test fixtures

If BMC401 (4-week lead) is selected as backup, the full build can be completed in approximately 5–6 weeks end-to-end.

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8. Open Items and Risks

Open actions

#	Action	Owner	Status
1	Re-quote SHI RDK-101D (Quote 5618 expired). Specify CF flange option.	Procurement	Pending
2	Confirm Cryomech PT205	Procurement	Pending

#	Action	Owner	Status
	120V availability when re-quoting		
3	Clarify Bama BMC401 mounting pattern, 60 Hz compatibility, SHI compressor compatibility	Engineering	Pending
4	Finalize cryostat vessel length from RDK-101D outline drawing dimensions	Engineering	Pending
5	Detailed top plate port layout (feedthrough count and placement)	Engineering	Pending
6	DUT PCB carrier design (depends on AQFP die pinout)	Engineering	Pending

Risk register

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Cryocooler lead time (12 wk)	Schedule slip	BMC401 backup (4 wk). Pre-assemble all other components.
RDK-101D quote expired	Price/availability change	Re-quote immediately. Budget has margin.
BMC401 not 120V compatible	Limits portability	Investigate SHI CNA-11RC + BMC401 cold head hybrid.
Custom machining delays	1–2 week slip	Use Protolabs/Xometry for fast-turn; simple parts.
MLI installation quality	Higher thermal load	>90% margin on both stages absorbs poor MLI.
Vacuum leak at O-ring seal	Pumpdown failure	Turbo pump can maintain vacuum continuously. Viton adequate to 10^{-7} Torr.

Appendix A: MLI Sourcing

10-layer MLI blankets are recommended for radiation shields larger than 150 mm diameter. Material needed for a 200 mm x 300 mm shield: ~2 m² each of reflector and spacer.

Option	Material	Cost	Lead Time
DIY (recommended)	Aluminized mylar (Amazon) + polyester netting (Joann Fabric)	$50–75	Days
Professional	Double-aluminized PET (Dunmore) + Dacron netting	$300–500	1–2 weeks
Pre-made blankets	Custom blankets (FrakoTerm, Poland)	$500+	2–4 weeks

DIY MLI has been validated by WSU HYPER lab as comparable in thermal performance to professional MLI. With >90% thermal margin, DIY is more than adequate.

MLI adds ~15–30 minutes to pumpdown time due to additional outgassing surface area. This is a manageable trade-off.

Appendix B: 3D Printed Parts (PLA at 4 K)

PLA has been validated at 4 K for non-thermally-conductive structural parts. Low thermal conductivity is a feature for thermal isolation.

Suitable for 3D printing:

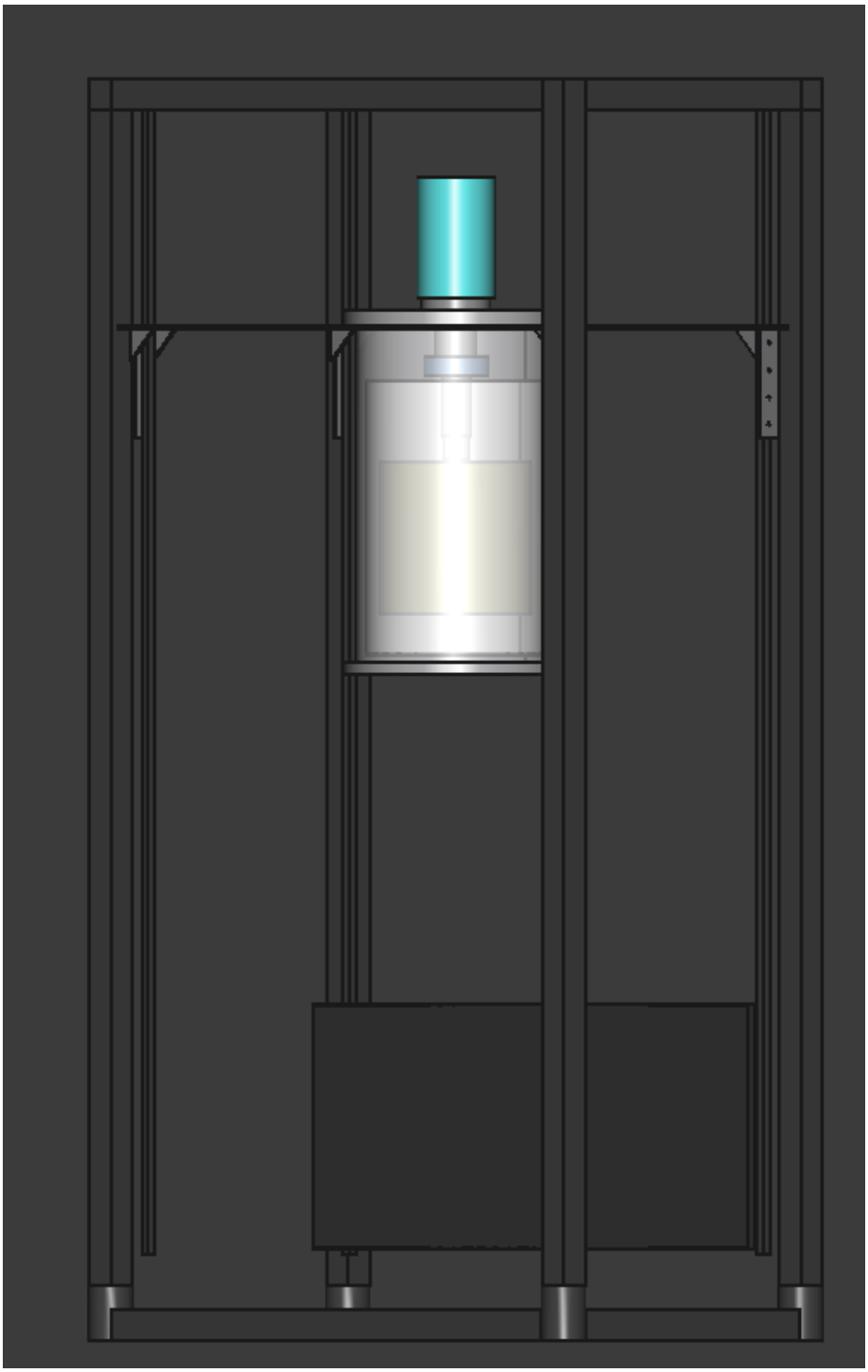
Part	Benefit
Wire routing bobbins (40 K)	Custom geometry for wire routing
DUT mount adapter	Fast iteration as DUT pinout changes
Magnetic shield brackets	Hold FINEMET (+ optional Pb foil) in position
Thermal isolation standoffs	Low-conductivity spacers between stages
Feedthrough strain reliefs	Cable management

Must remain metal: Radiation shield (Al), sample stage (Cu), vacuum vessel (SS), thermal straps (OFHC Cu).

PLA outgasses at room temperature in vacuum but this is handled by the turbo pump during pumpdown (adds a few minutes). Once cold, outgassing drops to near zero.

Appendix C: CAD Render

FreeCAD model of the complete rack-mounted system:



Rack Assembly

42U rack with cryostat mounted at U35 (top) and CNA-11R compressor at U1 (bottom). 6mm aluminum mounting frame supports cryostat flange on 19" rails.